



Lech Lecha

Genesis 12:1–17:27 — the call to Abram, Egypt, Lot, the war of the kings, two covenants, Hagar, and a new name

THE PARASHA BY THE NUMBERS

126

VERSES

1689

WORDS

414

DISTINCT ROOTS

13

HAPAX LEGOMENA

MOST FREQUENT ROOTS

אַבְרָם <i>Abram</i>	53
אָמַר <i>to say</i>	40
אֶל <i>to, toward</i>	34
אֲשֶׁר <i>who, which</i>	31
הָיָה <i>to be, become</i>	29
מֶלֶךְ <i>king</i>	29
ה' <i>the Name</i>	28
כָּל <i>all, every</i>	28
אֶרֶץ <i>land, earth</i>	26
בֵּין <i>between</i>	23

WHAT THE PARASHA CALLS GOD

ה' <i>the Name (Hasbem)</i>	28
אֱלֹהִים <i>God</i>	9
אֵל <i>El</i>	6
עֲלִיּוֹן <i>Elyon</i>	4
אֲדֹנָי <i>Adonai</i>	2
שַׁדַּי <i>Shaddai</i>	1

Six designations, and a clean hand-off between them. 'ה' speaks to Abram from 12:1 through 17:1, where He appears as אֵל; from that verse on, all nine אֱלֹהִים fall in chapter 17, the covenant of circumcision. Four of the six אֵל are אֱלִיִּן, Malki-tzedek's God, which Abram adopts in his oath to the king of Sodom: ה' אֵל עֲלִיִּן (14:22).

Averaging **13.4 words** a verse. The longest verse is **17:23** at 29 words — Abraham circumcising Ishmael and every male of his household הַיּוֹם הַזֶּה, on that very day; the shortest, **12:9**, has only 5 — הָלוֹךְ וְנִסּוּעַ הַנֶּגֶב, Abram moving on by stages toward the Negev.

THIRTEEN WORDS THAT OCCUR NOWHERE ELSE IN THE BIBLE

14:2 בֶּרַע <i>Bera, king of Sodom</i>	H1298	14:2 בִּרְשָׁא <i>Birsha, king of Gomorrah</i>	H1306
14:2 שִׁנְאָב <i>Shinab, king of Admab</i>	H8134	14:2 שְׁמֵמֶבֶר <שְׁמֵמֶבֶר> <i>Shemeber, king of Zeboim</i>	H8038
14:5 בְּעִשְׁתֵּרֶת קַרְנִים <עִשְׁתֵּרֶת קַרְנִים> <i>Ashteroth-karnaim, where Chedorlaomer struck the Rephaim</i>	H6255	14:5 הַזִּזִּים <זִזִּים> <i>the Zuzim, a people the four kings defeated</i>	H2104
14:5 בְּהֵם <הֵם> <i>Ham, the Zuzim's home (not Noah's son)</i>	H1990	14:6 אֵיל פָּאֶרָן <i>El-paran, by the wilderness</i>	H364
14:7 עֵין מִשְׁפָּט <i>Eyn Mishpat</i>	H5880	14:14 חֲנִיכִי <חֲנִיכִי> <i>Chanihi</i>	H2593

14:15 חֹבָה

H2327

Hobab, north of Damascus, where the pursuit ended

15:2 מֹשֶׁק

H4943

ben-mesbek: heir, "steward of my house"

15:19 הַקַּדְמוֹנִי

H6935

the Kadmonites, one of the ten nations promised to Abram

Hapax legomena, counted against the whole Tanakh: thirteen of this parasha's 414 roots are used exactly once in all of Scripture, and 205 appear only once here. Eleven of the thirteen sit in a single chapter — Genesis 14, the war of the four kings against the five, a chronicle full of kings and places the Bible never mentions again. One of them, הַיִּזְכִּיר, Abram's trained men, had a second life: Modern Hebrew made הַיִּזְכִּיר the word for a pupil or a youth-movement member. And מֹשֶׁק, in Abram's complaint וְבֶן־מֹשֶׁק בֵּיתִי (15:2), is the same word Israelis use for a farm or a household economy (מֹשֶׁק בֵּית).

12:1 מולדת

birthplace and kindred becomes the national homeland

לך־לך מארץך וממולדתך ומבית אביך — in Genesis מולדת belongs to the field of birth: where you were born and the kin you were born among, which is why it sits between "your land" and "your father's house." Zionist Hebrew gave the word the meaning that now dominates, the national homeland. Ben-Gurion writes of a מכורתו ההיסטורית and of planting the people במולדת; Kaplansky in 1929 calls Eretz Yisrael מולדתנו. The verse that tells Abram to leave his מולדת is the source of the word Israelis use for the land he was sent to — and Israeli schoolchildren study a subject called מולדת, homeland studies.

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שעור מולדת - בעקבות פרשת אלי גבע

A theatre poster designed by Mami Dar whose title plays on מולדת, the school subject of "homeland studies." The pun only works because מולדת now means the national homeland.

NLI · מולדת
FL212032236Yehuda Gabbay Theatre
Archive, Beit Ariela ·
National Library of Israel
FL212032236

15:1 שכר

a divine reward becomes a paycheck

אל־תירא אברהם אֶנֶכִּי מִגֵּן לֶךְ שָׂכָרְךָ הַרְבֵּה מֵאֵד — straight after the war of the kings, in which Abram refused even a thread or a sandal-strap of the spoils, God promises him a שכר, a reward. Revival Hebrew kept the reward but put the word to work in the economy: Smolenskin already writes of שכר בעד מפעלו, and Israeli Hebrew has the fully institutional שכר שחר, תלש שכר, שכר מינימום, שכר, עבודה, On its own, שכר today means wages; to say "reward" you reach for פרס or תגמול.

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חוק שכר מינימום

A 2004 government leaflet on the Minimum Wage Law. שכר here is plain pay, where Genesis's שכר is God's reward to Abram.

NLI · שכר
FL12308397Israel Ministry of Industry
and Trade · National
Library of Israel, 2004
FL12308397

15:6 צדקה

righteousness becomes charity

וְהֵאֱמַן בֵּה' וַיִּחְשְׁבֶהָ לוֹ צְדָקָה — Abram trusts, and it is counted to him as צדקה: righteousness, right standing, merit. Later Hebrew narrowed the word toward the act that most visibly sets things right, giving to the poor, and that is its default sense today: קופת צדקה, לתת צדקה, the pushke on the kitchen counter. Bergman's history of Jewish charity states the bridge in four words: הצדקה היא ענין של צדק. The verse's meaning survives in formal Hebrew, but a צדקה on a street poster is always a collection.

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צדקה גדולה - לטובת - ישיבת חסידי ברסלב - האור הנעלם

A fundraising poster for a Breslov yeshiva: צדקה גדולה, "a great charity," asks for donations — the later sense, not the righteousness credited to Abram.

NLI · צדקה
FL212043680National Library of Israel
collection
FL212043680

17:4 המון

a multitude of nations becomes the masses — and just "a lot"

וְהָיִיתָ לְאֵב הַמֶּהוּן — the verse that renames Abram as Abraham explains the new name with המון, "multitude." Mendele writes המון אנשים and המונים המונים; political Hebrew made המונים the masses and המוני העם the common people. Spoken Hebrew went further and turned the noun into an adverb of quantity: המון אנשים, "loads of people," תודה המון, "thanks a lot." On the Torah's own etymology, the name אברהם is built from the word Israelis now use for "tons."

ATTESTED · NATIONAL LIBRARY OF ISRAEL · 1920s

כרות בחירות מטעם רשימת הסתדרות השכנים, אגודת אוהלים וצריפים והארגון העממי

A 1920s election poster addressed to המוני העם, "the masses of the people" — המון as a political collective, not Genesis's multitude of nations.

המוני העם ·
NLI
FL6257021National Library of Israel,
1920s
FL6257021

SEVEN NARRATIVE UNITS, BY WORD COUNT



לְהִלֵּךְ	בְּמִצְרַיִם	הַפָּרֹדֶזֶן	מִלְחַמַּת הַמֶּלֶכִּים	בְּרִית בֵּין הַבְּתָרִים	הָגָר	בְּרִית מִילָה
The call & the journey 127 words	Famine: Sarai in Egypt 141 words	Parting from Lot 242 words	War of the kings, Malki- tzedek 343 words	Covenant between the pieces 258 words	Hagar & Ishmael 223 words	New names, covenant of circumcision 355 words

The call that names the parasha is its shortest unit — nine verses, 127 words, to leave land, birthplace and father's house. The two longest are the covenant of circumcision and the war of the kings: the parasha spends almost as many words on a campaign against Chedorlaomer as on the covenant that renames Abram and Sarai.

MORE FROM THE MODERN HEBREW LAYER

14:13 פָּלִיט

the one who escaped the battle → a refugee

14:23 שָׁרוֹף נֶעַל

a sandal-strap → a shoelace

17:1 תָּמִים

whole, blameless → innocent, naïve

14:14 חֲנִיָּה

Abram's trained retainers → a pupil, a youth-movement member

16:12 פָּרָא אָדָם

a wild-ass of a man → a boor

DEVICES MARKED IN THE MEGA BIBLE

12:1 מֵאֲרָצָהּ וּמִמּוֹלֶדְתָּהּ

bendiadys · Orlinsky; Speiser

13:13 רָעִים וְחֹטְאִים

bendiadys · Orlinsky

17:1 שִׁדְי

synecdoche · Sarna

12:13 וְחִיתָהּ נִפְשִׁי בְּגִלְגָּל

waw-explicativum · Reggio

15:16 הָאֶמְרִי

synecdoche · Reggio

17:10 כָּל-זָכָר

synecdoche · Reggio

MY NOTES

Nothing recorded yet — the notes field is empty for every verse of Genesis 12–17.